This Painted Desert

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/51644161.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta & Scorpia (She-Ra)

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Perfuma (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra)

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Role Reversal, Pre-Canon, Horde Perfuma (She-Ra), Scorpia is Not in the Horde (She-Ra), Pining, Cute, Perfuma-centric (She-Ra), Fluff and Angst, Hopeful Ending

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by samthehyena

Summary

During a trip to the forest, Force Captain Perfuma has a chance encounter with a princess.

Notes

I finally surrendered to the little voice in my head demanding role reversal Scorfuma.

See the end of the work for more notes

Where Plumeria once smelled of roses and violets it now stank of death. The sun cast orange shadows across the sky, glowing like molten lava. Biting her lip, Perfuma clutched onto the handles of the hovercraft as she averted her gaze from a shriveled up tree corpse.

The bark that used to house the Heart Blossom had turned fractured and gray with decay. The pink blossom that once swayed above the runestone had been reduced to a whisper in the breeze. Inhaling deeply, Perfuma tried to erase the metal images of willows dancing in the breeze and her people playing the flute as they pirouetted across meadows.

Readjusting her red vest, Perfuma frowned at the yellow-green badge pinned to her chest. A reminder of how she had become complacent in the system that had reduced her home to a wasteland.

Magenta prickly pears glittered on cacti. The only sign of life for milestones. Perfuma's saliva started to taste acidic at the bitter irony. Hardly anything grew in a kingdom once renowned for its flowers. Though perhaps it was fitting that like any other desert Plumeria had become the graveyard of an environment that used to bustle with life.

After all, wasn't the Waste the same? With its charcoal-colored fossilized corals hidden in the sand or the sand dollars buried by cliff sides. A reminder of how the Waste had once been an ocean floor. Though the waste was also different. The Waste's desolation had been the unfortunate consequence of nature running its course. Not a Horde invasion.

Perfuma's stomach turned at the sight of an antelope's skulls lying on the side of the road. She could not help but think of how much the ember streaks across the sky resembled blood. Soon enough she would have to watch bullets pierce holes through chest. In another life, it would have been Perfuma's destiny to birth blossoms with her touch. Instead, without a flicker of magic to her

name the best Perfuma could hope for was painting blood in the dirt with the barrel of her gun.

And there was no beauty in that.

In her head counted the eight and breathed out at regular intervals. She would only shoot herself in the foot with her fretting. Still, would remaining calm actually get her anywhere. Maybe she could stage a coup? No, that was only foolish wishful thinking.

That would only instigate more violence. Whether or not she obeyed the Horde's whims, bloodshed was inevitable. Peace was not a luxury Perfuma got to have.

Still, she eyed the red dot on the hovercraft's navigation pad with determination. Even if her kingdom had been stolen from her, perhaps she could steal back a small smile of freedom. Was Hordak or Shadow Weaver really going to notice one wayward hovercraft?

Besides, she was the best shot among the force captains. They'd be fools to discharge her just because she'd taken a short joyride to view the scenery in the forests.

A grin gradually stretched across Perfuma's face. She could hardly wait to see blue-tinted vines hanging from the trees. A chance to relive some semblance of the flora and fauna from her earlier childhood.

While the wind whipped through her blonde curls, Perfuma let out a wistful sigh. It had been half of an eternity since she had smelled nectar – she could barely even recall daffodils' aroma anymore.

As Perfuma's hovercraft wove through the forest, she could have sworn that she had spotted the hilt of a sword shining in the underbrush. It glowed like moonlight beneath the evening sun,

tugging at Perfuma's chest like gravity. Clicking a tongue, Perfuma tried to knock some sense into herself.

Weapons were a dime a dozen; she had no reason to grow so infatuated with a random sword.

Instead she focused on the sunrays trickling through the canopy of trees and the moss that squelched as her hovercraft sped past it. Craning her neck toward the sky, Perfuma breathed in the scent of blossoming roses and imagined every passing moment could have been enveloped in flowers if her people had not been dragged to the trenches.

Still, her hands seemed to move almost on their own. Almost drifting into a trance, Perfuma could have sworn she heard the echo of a choir resounding through her skull. Breaths hitching, Perfuma pivoted the hovercraft in the direction she thought she had spotted a sword.

Only to instantaneously collide with a tree.

As the hovercraft sped toward the ground, Perfuma got knocked against a tree. A trickle of blood ran down her temple while vines circled around her wrists, leaving her hanging upside. The more she buckled against her restraints, the more they tightened. Basking in sweat, Perfuma's vision grew cloudy. Kicking at the tree she was trapped in, Perfuma realized her legs had gotten stuck in the vines too.

Fantastic.

A thorn pricked Perfuma's side as she tried to tear through the vines to no avail. Palms growing raw in the process, Perfuma cursed the blood rushing to her head as she remained suspended upside down. God, she was starting to hate vines. Even cactai were better because at least they hadn't betrayed Perfuma yet by trapping her in their clutches.

Rustling sound from a thornbush and Perfuma gritted her teeth. Not missing her beat, Perfuma reached for the gun in her holster

even though the gesture made the vines dig deep enough into her flesh to draw blood.

Great, now I'm probably going to get eaten by some wild beast because the vines decided to tackle me. Where are runestone plant powers when you need them?

Perfuma bit down on her gum and steeled her breath. No point in panicking over countless possibilities. She had to stay focused or risk missing her mark when push came to shove.

Yet as a silhouette emerged from the bushes Perfuma found herself breathless. A gold diadem shone upon silvery hair. Pincers the color of roses made Perfuma's heart ache for the flowers she longed for the most. Big dark eyes blinked back at Perfuma whose pulse raced at the sight of a crooked smile.

Cute . Setting her index finger on her gun's trigger, Perfuma buried her invasive instinct thoughts. She couldn't get distracted. Not when the diadem gave her all the details she needed – and there was no way a princess would show mercy toward a Horde soldier.

Sure, Perfuma had a feeling that the posters and Horde fear mongering about princesses were highly exaggerated, but Perfuma knew that the enemy could still be deadly. Magic was not a weapon to be trifled with. And the small sparks of red lighting along the stranger's claws only confirmed Perfuma's line of thought.

As the stranger approached her, Perfuma whipped around her gun. "Get away from me! I have a gun and I'm not afraid to use it."

The stranger held up her claws in surrender. "Easy now, soldier. I just want to help you down."

Perfuma narrowed her eyes at the stranger as she tried to ignore how clammy her hands had gotten around the gun. Everytime she thought about pulling it her guts did somersaults. Perhaps she

was a pacifist at heart. But that didn't matter. If she backed down she could end up dead.

She practically hissed at the stranger, hoping that the princess would be deterred from staying in Perfuma's vicinity once confronted by her hostile tone. "What? So you can take me back to your rebel base and drag secrets out of me."

"No… I…" The princess stuttered as she gawked at Perfuma dumbfounded. "How about you stop pointing your gun at me, then I'll help you down and we'll call it a truce."

Perfuma wearily lifted her finger off the trigger. As much as she prided herself in standing her ground and rooting herself in place, she had enough sense to know when she was outmatched. She eyed the scarlet electricity flickering out the stranger, wondering why the sight felt so similar to the lightning sensation zigzagging through her chest.

Besides, some naive part of her thought that the princesses warm smile again. So different from the Horde where rising to a higher station took precedence over teammates. Not any sign of genuine harmony even though every soldier was a cog in the same machine. For a moment, Perfuma was a rose reaching toward the sunshine of a person in front of her.

"Fine," Perfuma relented.

The tension from the stranger's shoulders dissipated as she approached Perfuma. Yet the princess hesitated as she held her claws close to the vines holding Perfuma in place. Her brows knotted together as if she was scared Perfuma would yell at her for being monstrous. Inhaling deeply, Perfuma nodded toward her restraints to give the princess the go ahead to free her.

After all, a princess with claws was far from monstrous. Especially, as she weaved her claws gently in between the vines so as not to knick Perfuma's skin. Arthropod qualities did not make someone a monster. The way the cadets wearily looked at Shadow Weaver

spoke of monsters. Real monsters took the form of the hands that tore the Heart Blossom away, leaving nothing but the empty husk of a tree behind.

Perfuma knocked her head against the tree as she hurtled toward the ground after the princess snapped the vines. She could taste the iron flavor of blood staining her lips after she stumbled to her feet. Thank goddess for the moss that cushioned her fall or she would have had a concussion – and there was no way that would have gone over well with her superiors.

Jaw going slack, the princess reached toward Perfuma as if to wipe away the blood but the soldier stepped back. Nothing was free in life. If someone shared their rations with you they would expect you to cover up their missteps in training. And Perfuma likely already owned the princess for freeing her. No need to dig herself into an even bigger abyss of dept.

"I can take care of it myself.

Ripping off the hem of her shirt, Perfuma applied pressure to the wound. Yet the longer she held the fabric in place, the more the woods seemed to spiral around her. The blue haze of the forest started to turn to static and the smell of recent rainfall grew increasingly intense. Vision blurring, Perfuma felt tiredness envelop her when the cool touch of a claw grounded her back in reality.

Confusing, Perfuma stared back at the princess. In an earnest effort, the princess held the makeshift rag to Perfuma's forehead and kept picking it back up again. Chest thumping, Perfuma held back a gasp. The way that the princess flushed as Perfuma looked at her resembled a primrose bush in May. And even though the princess kept slipping up, she kept pushing forward.

The opposite of how Plumeria had surrendered.

"Why are you helping me?" Perfuma asked before she had even fully processed the question.

“Because you looked like you needed it,” the princess said bluntly.

Perfuma blinked back at the princess, trying to detect a lie. A sign that she was waiting to tear into Perfuma and demand a favor in return for her kindness. Instead, the princess nervously scratched the back of her head. Her dark eyes shone at Perfuma, swelling with straight-forwardness like she didn’t need some deeper rhyme or reason to help someone in need. Even if it was an enemy soldier.

In the clearing, Perfuma noticed the beads of sweat forming on the princess’s neck beneath the searing sun. Perfuma hummed to herself as she retrieved a flask of water attached to her belt. Maybe the stranger genuinely did not expect something in return, but Perfuma thought that it was only fair to atone for initial hostility.

Extending an olive branch, Perfuma held out the flask. “Want any water?”

“How do I know it isn’t poisoned?” the princess chuckled and winked at Perfuma.

Not missing a beat, Perfuma uncapped the flask and took a sip of water. “See. It’s all good.”

“Guess it is!”

The princess graciously accepted the flask and the sound of claws clinking against metal reminded Perfuma of the whistling of flutes from her childhood. It was only when the princess set her lips on the flask that it dawned on Perfuma what she had just done. An indirect kiss.

Heat rushed to Perfuma’s face at the realization – but regardless she struggled to grapple with the idea that she would have to wash the flask eventually and wipe away any trace of her perfect stranger.

Smiling, the princess handed back the flask. “I’m Scorpia by the way.”

“Perfuma.” Logically, she knew that she was not supposed to offer up information to the enemy but Scorpia’s warmth simply made her open up like a sunflower in a well-lit meadow.

For a quiet blissful moment, Scorpia and Perfuma sat beside one another and basked in the symphony of the forest. The soft footsteps of deer treading through grass in the distance. The whisper of the wind rustling through the trees. Giddiness pooled into Perfuma’s chest. Whatever consequences lied before her, venturing into the forest had been worthwhile if even for a moment.

Stealing glances at Scorpia, Perfuma eyed her toned arms. The sturdy arch of her back. The kind of person who would have easily made rank in the Horde – unlike Perfuma who had to shoot through thousands of practice targets until anyone dared to believe she was more than just a delicate flower.

Perfuma chewed on the inside of her mouth as she recalled the past scrolls curled up in her chest of drawers inviting her to princess prom. Part of her had always wondered whether there was any truth to the caricatures hung up within the Horde’s walls. Maybe Angella’s gaze really did radiate murderousness.

But even if all the posters were nothing but propaganda, Perfuma was certain of what the other princesses would see in her. A traitor. A weed that marred the rebellion’s harmonious garden of solidarity.

Still, maybe in another life Perfuma would have been brave enough to enter the ballroom. And maybe just, maybe she would have encountered Scorpia a little bit sooner.

Tracing circles along the ground, Perfuma sighed wistfully. “You’re pretty alright… for a princess.”

“Not so bad yourself. For a horde soldier that is,” Scorpia snorted.

“Hey, I’m not just any horde soldier. I’m a force captain.” Perfuma puffed her cheeks in false indignance and gestured toward her badge.

“Looks fancy. Rising up the ranks?”

“Mhm.” Perfuma nodded.

“That’s fantastic!” Scorpia pumped a fist in the air as her eyes practically glowed. “I think I might get to lead a rebellion squadron soon.”

“Well, I wish you the best of luck.”

The knots in Perfuma’s stomach unknotted as she imagined Scorpia at the helm of an attack, tearing Horde tanks apart. How Scorpia would narrow her eyes with determination as she charged toward the enemy to reclaim some part of Etheria that was stolen. To no avail Perfuma tried to silence the voice in her head that kept squealing over how infatuating Scorpia would be as a squadron leader.

“Are you supposed to be cheering your enemies on to get promoted?”

“I suppose not. But what Hordak doesn’t know won’t kill him.”

At that Scorpia elbowed Perfuma in the side not fully aware of the extent of her own strength. A small purple bruise began to swell and Scorpia gawked at in horror. An ache cinched through Perfuma’s ribcage as she set a gentle hand on Scorpia’s arm.

“I know it wasn’t on purpose. Plus, I bruise like a peach. It’s not on you.”

“But still –”

“Then, how about to make it up to me you give me some company while I fix my hovercraft?” Perfuma offered.

“Okay, I can do that!”

Rolling up the sleeves of the white shirt beneath her vest, Perfuma knelt in front of the hovercraft which had the panel covering its main circuit board pried open. As Scorpia sat nearby watching, Perfuma wished that the Horde logo branded onto the back of her vest would vanish. That world of a divide between her and Scorpia could magically disappear with a fingersnap.

Pearls of sweat formed a necklace around Perfuma’s neck as her hands traversed the circuitry. Of course, she had basic training in electronics – still a hovercraft was a little above her paygrade. Especially, since she had spent most of her training practicing her sniping skills from the higher levels of the Horde base.

A breath brushed against Perfuma’s skin, making her sit taller. A pincer pointed toward a section in the main circuitboard’s lower right corner. “You need to replace that blue wire there.”

Obliging, Perfuma reached over to open the hovercraft’s dashboard to find a replacement. Biting her lip, she kept her hands steady and did not dare to even speak until she set the new wire perfectly in place.

“I would not have taken you for a technology expert,” Perfuma said.

“What can I say? I learned from the best. Entrapa’s a whiz when it comes to science. Robots, hovercrafts – you name it – Entrapa’s a pro.”

“Is she a princess too?”

“Yeah! From Dryl.”

Scorpia’s voice practically dripped with fondness. She could never imagine anyone from the Horde speaking of her so positively save for her superiors. The bulk of the cadets thought that the only reason she had made Force Captain was because of her lineage,

Heck, Perfuma could still recall the icy set of heterochromatic cat eyes staring daggers at her back when she got promoted.

“It certainly is good to hear that the rebels at least have some camaraderie.”

“Don’t have friends back in the Horde?”

Rolling her sleeves back down, Perfuma glared at Scorpia. She really had to hit the nail on the head, didn’t she? “How dare you make that kind of accusation?!”

With a frown Scorpia stared down at her feet. “Oh, sorry. My bad. I shouldn’t have assumed.”

As Scorfuma deflated like a saddened puppy, Perfuma frantically waved her hands in front of herself. “No, it’s alright. I’m not the most popular back there. It's a dog eat dog world out there.”

Scorpia nodded firmly. “Sounds tough.”

No pity lined her tone. Just raw compassion. Understanding flashed in the sharpness of her jawline as Scorpia stared at the ridges of her claws. Like she knew the sting of being anchored to preconceived notions all too well.

“I manage,” Perfuma said.

Closing the circuit board, Perfuma held her hands behind her back and stepped closer toward Scorpia hoping to diffuse some of the tension weighing in the woods.

“Looks like rebellion princesses are nothing like what the Horde says.”

Scorpia raised a brow. “What were you expecting?”

“I don’t know. Maybe some maniacal laughter and fangs,” Perfuma laughed nervously.

“Well, I don’t have either of those down, but maybe these are enough to make me an *evil princess* .” Scorpia clinked her claws together. The faintest quiver of doubt rested in her bold voice.

“Nah, you’re the furthest thing from evil,” Perfuma reassured.

“Thanks for the compliment!”

“Anytime.”

As Scorpia beamed at Perfuma like she was the sun itself, she buried the urge to leave her entire life behind so she could forever plant herself right beside Scorpia. But she had to stay calm, she had to stay rational. And for now this blissful stolen moment was enough for Perfuma.

Wandering mindlessly, Perfuma spun through the woods. She ran her fingers against coarse tree bark and cupped her hand around a white blossom with a yellowed center. Perfumia tried not to choke up at the sight of her kingdom’s namesake.

“I really missed flowers.”

“Don’t see much of those back home?”

“Yeah, it’s pretty much a wasteland.” Perfuma found the words spilling out of her without giving her a chance to second guess herself. Maybe the lack of connection to her peers made her so willing to lay everything out in the open to the first possible confidant she crossed paths with.

“If I could connect to Plumeria’s Runestone, that would be a different story… but it is what it is. At least, there’s cacti.”

Now Perfuma was hardly a big fan or cacti. Unsurprisingly even cacti could not thrive in the horde barracks without an ounce of sunlight. Plus, even though they were supposedly low-maintenance but in actuality Perfuma struggled to strike the correct balance and neither underwater or overwater them. But in a desolate wasteland she couldn’t exactly be picky. Perfuma’s

everyday plant interactions were destined either be with cacti or nothing at all.

Long live the princess of Plumeria, heir to nothing but sand and dust.

"Well, I think cacti flowers are nice too."

"Is that so?"

"Yeah! Though I might be a bit biased. Because scorpions, cacti and deserts… kinda go hand in hand, you know."

"I guess they do."

Perfuma smiled softly. As much as she hated deserts, despised living in a world run by war and resented cacti, seeing that someone could be at peace with themselves was soothing. Scorpia was like a creek weaving its way tree roots, creating a new path forward in spite of obstacles in its path. Somehow Scorpia had burst through the clouds of negative energy in the way that Perfuma's attempts at morning tea rituals never could.

Craning her neck toward the sky, Perfuma spotted swatches of blue. A sign that dusk was approaching faster by the second. Time to hurry back to her barrack before she had her ear chewed off for missing curfew. Worst case scenario she would miss out on her herbal tea rations for recklessly treading a thin line between casual rule-breaking and outright mutiny.

As Perfuma stepped onto the hovercraft, Scorpia cleared her throat. "Need help getting home?"

"You want to aid an enemy soldier in getting back to safety?"

Scorpia shrugged. "Eh, I wouldn't want to lose the friendliest face on enemy lines."

"That… makes sense," Perfuma said.

Rationally, Perfuma was well aware that she could exit the forest safely on her own. Save for getting distracted from a supposed random sword in the woods, Perfuma's piloting skills were more than satisfactory. Still, Perfuma was far from opposed to the idea of Scorpia following her to the edge of the woods.

Maybe she was greedy for wanting her stolen moment to last just a little bit longer.

Perfuma held out her hand and Scorpia accepted. Reveling in the weight of the claw in her palm, Perfuma tugged Scorpia onto the hovercraft. The two of them grabbed onto the bar of the hovercraft and as the engine roared to life, Perfuma basked in how Scorpia smelled of copper.

Wind blowing through her hair, Perfuma kept looking at Scorpia's face, trying to engrave every detail into her mind. Who knew if they would see each other again? At princess prom, if Perfuma dared to show her face there. And perhaps this year she would – because she knew that at least one person would not look down on her like she was filth.

While the trees gradually grew less dense, Scorpia spoke up. "About the runestone… you're a princess?"

"I am. And I'm also a Horde soldier," Perfuma choked out.

As Perfuma steadied her grip on the hovercraft, she noted that Scopia did not stare at her expectantly. A comfortable silence instead filled the hovercraft like Scorpia was giving Perfuma the room to elaborate if she so desired.

"My parents had to make the diplomatic decision when the Horde invaded. It was for the best. Most of Plumeria's people weren't the fighting type anyways."

No that it mattered when the Horde had drafted the bulk of Plumeria's citizens into their front lines.

"I'm sorry," Scorpia said.

“What for? It wasn’t your fault.”

“It’s just I couldn’t imagine life without my magic.” Scorpia stared at a spark of wayward electricity. “It must hurt not having it.”

“I’m alright. It’s not like I’ve known anything else.”

But in spite of her words, Perfuma couldn’t help but stare at the plumerias hanging from trees as she wishes that she could make flowers snake across the ground with the flick of her wrist.

Once the hovercraft reached the edge of the forest, Perfuma only reluctantly brought it to a halt. Part of her wanted to wrap Scorpia into an embrace and not let go. Because she could hardly recall the last time someone looked at her like she was a person rather than a weapon.

She could only hope that fate would be kind enough to let her find Scorpia’s smile again.

Stepping off the hovercraft, Scorpia gave Perfuma a small stilted wave. “See you on the front lines someday.”

“Yeah. And I’ll make sure to miss the mark when I aim my gun at you.”

“I’ll do the same with my lightning,” Scorpia said before she disappeared into the line of trees.

As the hovercraft’s engine revved back to life, Perfuma kept her gaze fixed on the horizon. She didn’t know if she would be able to leave all she ever knew behind if she looked over her shoulder again even one more time.

She had expected to find flowers on her outing, but instead something entirely new had bloomed. The faint outline of the moon cast shadows in the dunes as cacti twinkled like emeralds. The moonlight intermingling with the setting sun seemed to set the desert ablaze. Maybe Scorpia had cast rose-colored glasses

over Perfuma’s eyes – but for once the desert looked like a painting rather than a lifeless wasteland.

End Notes

This was my first time writing for the She-Ra fandom so I hope the fic read okay <3

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!